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DIGITAL BATTLEGROUNDS: THE POWER DYNAMICS AND GOVERNANCE OF CONTEMPORARY PLATFORMS

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The ubiquity of digital platforms is undeniable, as is their transactional efficiency and world-flattening possibilities. Yet, these platforms are contested battlegrounds where stakeholder power struggles reflect and influence broader societal turbulence. In the emerging era, alongside the blinding speed and global reach of the gig economy are looming specters of rentier capitalism, digi-serfdom, misinformation, data exploitation, digital addiction, and near-ungovernable algorithmic agents. To date, scholarly focus on digital platforms has been on their transactional features and impacts, dimensionalizing governance mechanisms as emanating from old economy conceptions of bottom-up or top-down checks and balances, or incentives and efficiencies. These emphases, while useful for understanding managerial control of digital platforms, largely ignore the extent to which digital platforms are contested organizational spaces, shaped by complex power dynamics. Foucault (1998: 63) asserted that power is everywhere, and that those who hold power are rarely well-understood by those who are subject to it. In seeking to rebalance and reorient digital platform research, we analyze and integrate existing research along four dimensions that shape platform power dynamics: actors, relations, faces, and struggle. We establish a future research agenda—including six testable propositions—that more thoroughly engages the critical, yet untapped, expertise of management scholars concerning platform power.

From the heated Congressional debates over banning TikTok (Doctorow, 2023) to the alarming disclosures of Instagram's detrimental effects on teenagers' mental health (Susser, Roessler & Nissenbaum, 2019), and from the increasingly reckless aggregation and use of stakeholder data (Taylor, 2014) to mistrust of black-box, algorithm-based decision-making (Agerfalk, 2020), digital platforms have come under intense scrutiny for the profound influence they exert over platform participants and society writ large (Lv & Schotter, 2024; Sadowski, 2020; Van Dijck, Nieborg & Poell, 2019). The massive gains in choice, buyer power, and transactional efficiencies have fundamentally altered economic exchange across many industries (Andreoni & Roberts, 2022; Hunt, 2013), yet the bold predictions that internet-based multisided platforms would spawn a democratizing diffusion of political, cultural, social, and economic power have proved to be overly optimistic, and possibly illusory (Andreucci, Garcıa-Lamarca, Wedekind & Swyngedouw, 2017; Taylor, 2014). While the considerable benefits of platforms emerged quickly, a full reckoning of their detrimental aspects is only now becoming apparent, especially with the growing reliance on

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sophisticated algorithms designed to govern platforms in increasingly opaque ways (Cameron, 2024; Rahman, Karunakaran & Cameron, 2024). This rapidly evolving landscape has created a scholarly imperative to better understand the digital platform battlefield and the power dynamics that will continue to shape their societal impacts (Rahman et al., 2024; Ricart, Snihur, Carrasco-Farré & Berrone, 2020; Thomas, Le Masson, Weil & Legrand, 2021).

In particular, the complex and dynamic processes that continually shape the who, what, when, where, why, and how of platform governance have emerged as matters of intense debate among scholars, platform participants, and policymakers. In one sense, platforms are a classic form of rentier capitalism (Birch, 2020; Komljenovic, 2021), an arrangement in which owners earn profits while the uncompensated labor and information costs borne by platform participants generate the primary value (Harvey, 2010; Sadowski, 2020). Yet, there are also undeniable efficiencies that accrue to participants and complementors (Miric & Jeppesen, 2023; Rietveld & Eggers, 2017; Young & Suarez, 2023) who benefit from the platform's perceived legitimacy (Essen, Frishammar & Cenamor, 2023), enabling transactions and social connections on a global scale. Thus, the blinding speed and global reach of the gig economy exist side by side with the specters of rentier capitalism, digiserfdom, rampant data exploitation, misinformation, digital addiction, and near-ungovernable algorithmic agents.

As an asset class with few historical parallels, the nature, substance, and impact of platform ownership are confoundingly difficult to describe (Karger, 2023). Among management and organizational scholars, much of the focus to date has been directed toward the transactional nature of platforms, dimensionalizing governance mechanisms as emanating from old economy conceptions of bottom-up or top-down checks and balances (Rahman et al., 2024), incentives and efficiencies (Chen, Yi, Li & Tong, 2022), and competitive logics (Cennamo, 2021; Gawer, 2022). This scholarly tilt is not without foundation. Efficiency gains due to improved coordination and the rapid scalability of platforms lend credence to the extensive transaction cost theoretical (TCT) framing that dominates the platform governance research (Adner, Puranam & Zhu, 2019; Kretschmer, Leiponen, Schilling & Vasudeva, 2022; Täuscher & Laudien, 2018). Yet, there is a notable incompleteness to this emphasis on efficiency and managerial control. In particular, the primacy of the "efficient governance" hypothesis underestimates the extent to which platforms have emerged as battlegrounds; contested spaces shaped in fundamental ways by complex power dynamics oriented toward the control of modern society (Lu, Zhou & Fan, 2023; Young & Suarez, 2023).

As Foucault (1976) prophetically argued, power is everywhere, and this appears to be ominously true regarding platform governance. The missing link for management research—and the leading pathway for the management field to contribute multidisciplinary insights concerning digital platforms—is power; what it is and where it resides. The challenge for scholars—and the purpose of this integrative review—is how to redirect the trajectory of platform governance research toward an agenda that more fully contemplates and incorporates the inescapable role of power dynamics (see, e.g., Fleming & Spicer, 2014 for a comprehensive review of power dynamics in organizational research). Management scholars have at their disposal a diverse array of conceptual tools that are useful in decoding, assessing, predicting, and prescribing the complex power relations (Martin, 2024) inherent in platform governance (Fleming & Spicer, 2007, 2014), yet the field has been slow to recognize the opportunity to put these tools to productive use. Our goal is to facilitate more thorough engagement of management scholars concerning the structures, aims, and outcomes of complex power dynamics in shaping digital platform governance.

In seeking to rebalance and reorient the future of digital platform research, our multidisciplinary, integrative approach involves an analytical review incorporating four key dimensions that shape power dynamics: *actors, relations*, *faces*, and *power struggles*. By organizing and assessing the platform governance literature through the application of these four dimensions, we extend and enhance foundational work concerning organizational power by Fleming and Spicer (2007, 2014). Following Chen, Tong, and colleagues (2022), our analysis of platform *actors* examines owners, complementors, and participant-users, to which we add algorithms, reflecting the growing role of intelligent algorithms and artificial intelligence (AI) as platform actors. Power *relations*, consistent with Schüßler, Attwood, Kirchner, and Schor (2021), are captured through a detailed assessment of mutuality, autonomy, and control, to which we add adversarial relations, which has increasingly emerged as a dominant theme in the contested relationships circumscribing platform governance (Sadowski, 2020; Van Dijck et al., 2019). *Faces* of power (Fleming & Spicer, 2014; Lukes, 1974) are

comprised of coercion, manipulation, domination, and subjectification. Lastly, we take stock of the contributions to and gaps in the platform literature concerning the dynamic nature of power through the lens of political *struggle* (Fleming & Spicer, 2007), manifested across four subdimensions consisting of refusal, voice, escape, and creation.

By recasting digital platform governance through the lens of these power dimensions, our integrative review offers fertile ground for future research, which we discuss in the final section of the article. Through this re-architecting of the platform governance literature, we undertake stronger, clearer, multilevel definitional work, leading to a set of testable propositions that speak to the unique challenges and opportunities of digital platform governance and power dynamics.

THE DIGITAL PLATFORMS LITERATURE

Although scholars tend to equate platforms with modern manifestations of digitalized technologies, from a commercial perspective multisided platforms have existed for millennia as venues that match buyers and sellers while enabling venue owners to profit by provisioning safe and efficient exchange (Periera, 2022). In recent years, however, the speed and scale at which digital platforms change and evolve has increased dramatically, producing a dizzying array of platforms—and associated ecosystems, services, and communities—that would have been unimaginable only a few decades ago. While these contemporary digital platforms exude a vestigial connection to the sociocultural and economic roots of pre-digital marketplaces, they have utterly upended the locus of platform governance (Gorwa, 2019a), in part by amplifying the role of complex power dynamics (Altman, Nagle & Tushman, 2022).

However, despite numerous examples highlighted across the rapidly growing scholarly literature on digital platforms, management scholars tend to address the role of power dynamics through the lens of managerial control. Indeed, numerous studies, including several recent systematic reviews (e.g., Altman et al., 2022; Chen, Richter & Patel, 2021; McIntyre & Srinivasan, 2017; Rahman et al., 2024; Rietveld & Schilling, 2021), acknowledge the importance and role of power dynamics on digital platforms, but focus mostly on the factors that influence and shape managerial control. Exploring and analyzing the role of complex power dynamics on digital platforms, thus, requires two complementary approaches: (1) analyzing existing management and organizational research in the digital platforms literature to discern how these studies implicitly address the role of power dynamics among a plurality of stakeholders; and (2) integrating these findings with a rapidly growing body of research spanning numerous fields of study outside of management, which explicitly analyze and explore the role of power dynamics.

Identifying and Analyzing Reviews of the Digital Platforms Literature

The emergence of digital platforms as essential forums for economic and social exchange has generated a rapidly growing organizational field in recent years that impacts and shapes the lives and work of billions of people. Indeed, recent studies report that seven of the 10 largest firms in the world in terms of market capitalization are digital platforms (Hendrikse, Adriaans, Klinge & Fernandez, 2022). Unsurprisingly, just as large-scale bureaucratic organizations captured the zeitgeist of corporate power in the industrial age (e.g., Chandler, 1962), and the attention of organizational scholars for more than a century, the global scale, scope, and influence of digital platforms continues to generate a growing number of studies situated across numerous scholarly fields. Given the breadth of this literature, organizational scholars have developed several comprehensive reviews of existing platforms and digital platforms research to analyze key topics, themes, and perspectives.

Table 1 summarizes the key dimensions of recent review articles in the platforms and digital platforms literature published in recent decades. All of these reviews touch on important themes broadly related to governance on platforms. For example, Rietveld and Schilling (2021) address the central issue of competition and competitive dynamics, while McIntyre and Srinivasan (2017) analyze the governance issues surrounding networks and platform quality. Altman et al. (2022) examine questions relating to governance structure and user communities within managed ecosystems, Chen, Tong, and colleagues (2022) review literature concerning the efficient design of digital platforms, and Rahman et al. (2024) explore the drivers of accountability.

While each of these reviews touches on aspects of power, all notably set aside these questions to focus on other dimensions of platform governance. For example, Chen, Tong, and colleagues (2022: 153) note that "the legal, exclusive ownership of the critical productive asset (i.e., the platform interface or architecture) gives platform owners the power to prohibit, compel, and coerce." They further note

TABLE 1
Summaries of Recent Reviews in the Platforms and Digital Platforms Literatures

Review Article	Rietveld and Schilling (2021)	McIntyre and Srinivasan (2017)	Altman et al. (2022)	Chen, Tong, et al. (2022)	Rahman et al. (2024)	This Review
Type of platform	General	General	General	Digital	Digital	Digital Platforms
Main relationships to govern	Among different participants in a platform ecosystem	Between different sides in a platform network	User communities within managed ecosystems	Between platform owners and complementors	Multisided triadic perspective (platform owner, provider, customer)	Complex relational ties among owners, complementors, users, and algorithms
Key governance issue(s)	Competition	Networks and platform quality	Governance structure	Value, governance, and design	Accountability	Power dynamics

that the primary purpose of their review is "to analyze how platform owners may leverage various governance mechanisms and design features to incentivize and/or control complementors and their activities" (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022: 154). Rietveld and Schilling (2021) adopt a similar approach by focusing on the role of "market power" and acknowledging how a platform's strategies shape how power is distributed across different actors in a platform ecosystem—again, mostly from the perspective of manager-owners. Although Rahman et al. (2024) extensively discuss power in their recent review, ours differs through its central focus on power dynamics instead of accountability—yielding different insights and future research directions. For example, Rahman et al. (2024: 41) argue that "multi-sided platforms require multi-sided accountability systems that reinforce accountability processes among platform owners, providers, and customers." Although we adopt their multisided perspective, we take a dramatically different approach to the consideration of platform power by highlighting the dynamic contestation among stakeholders and profound consequences of the struggle for power.

Each of the existing reviews references different faces of power (i.e., coercion, manipulation, etc.), but since the primary focus of each review is to address the transactional drivers of platform governance, the role of power is neither fully examined nor substantively addressed in these reviews. Our assessment of recent reviews indicates that while management and organizational scholars acknowledge the importance of power to the governance of digital platforms, existing work has not yet fully grappled with the nature, role, and impact of that power.

Defining Digital Platforms

Next, to set the parameters of our review, we analyze existing approaches to defining "digital platforms." Based on our analyses of existing reviews, we follow Chen, Tong, and colleagues (2022: 148) and accept that a platform is "an interface that facilitates interactions between different parties, usually complementors and customers." A newspaper, for example, may connect buyers and sellers through advertising while simultaneously connecting readers to news and information. Alternatively, an internal communication site, such as a company's intranet discussion board, is a business platform that connects employees. Such a broad-based definition of a platform highlights the tension between economic perspectives (e.g., Rochet & Tirole, 2003), which tend to use the terms "markets" and "platforms" synonymously versus those that derive primary meaning from the technological nature of modern platforms or the social instructiveness platforms promote (Baldwin & Woodard, 2009; Gawer, 2014).

For the purposes of our discussion, we specify that economic platforms—typically involving transaction-focused, two-sided markets—constitute a subset of the broader universe of platforms. In our view, defining platforms only as transaction-based economic platforms is overly restrictive, as it excludes a broad swath of other platform categories that are essential to developing a managerial and organizational understanding of the power dynamics associated with multisided digital platforms. Platform power is germane to a broader set of interactions than those arising exclusively through financial transactions. For example, the uncompensated use of participant data by a social platform owner does not involve financial exchange between participants and owners, but it does involve

value creation and value appropriation and, in that sense, speaks volumes about the power dynamics of social media platforms.

Then, too, there is the matter of digitalization. The emergence of digital platforms, both as new business models and as novel societal venues, has led to a variety of new research, and multiple, competing conceptualizations of the same phenomena (Chen et al., 2021). Scholars note that digital platforms contain elements of institutions, markets, and technologies (De Reuver, Carsten & Basole, 2018). For example, Lee, Liang, Cheng, Tang, and Yuen's (2022: 1703) definition describes digital platforms as "online transaction platforms featuring an online marketplace that facilitates actual transactions between suppliers and buyers by connecting them." In this case, we take exception to the specificity of the definition, particularly the clear emphasis on the necessity of buyers and sellers pursuing and consummating transactions. Chen, Tong, Tang, and Han (2022) have a specific reason for accepting this definitional boundary since they are seeking to situate platform governance squarely within the domain of TCT (Coase, 1937; Williamson, 1975, 1981, 1996).

Other scholars adopt a similar approach to that which we take in our integrative review (e.g., Frenken & Fuenfschilling, 2021; Sadowski, 2020; Thomas et al., 2021), arguing that the power dynamics of digital platforms are not well-serviced by a reliance on the TCT-tinged language of hybrid organizational forms. There is also evidence that the focus on transactions has unintentionally led to an uncomfortable tendency for the term "multisided platform" to be used interchangeably with "digital platform" and even "economic platform" (Altman et al., 2022). Far more palatable is the definition developed by Chen, Tong, et al. (2022: 151), wherein digital platforms are referred to as "a type of platform that serves as a standardized digital interface and utilizes digital technologies to facilitate interactions between different parties."

To be as inclusive and consistent as possible in our review, we opted to define digital platforms broadly, including both multisided transactional buying, selling, and trading, as well as the broader set of venues for nonmonetary social exchanges (De Reuver et al., 2018; Sanchez-Cartas & Leon, 2021). This is essential for a comprehensive exposition of power dynamics, but also for practical reasons, since some of the best-known examples of digital platforms encompass both economic and social exchanges, such as Alibaba, Amazon, Facebook, and Google. Other platforms with specialized applications that still fall within our definition are found in healthcare (Bez, Georgescu & Farazi, 2023), scientific data reporting (Cavallo, Burgers, Ghezzi & Van de Vrande, 2022), and remote work communication (Dassel & Klein, 2023). By casting a wide net, we conduct a review that is faithful to the exploration of digital platforms as "free" spaces for fulfillment, contention, and all that falls in between.

Analyzing the Digital Platforms Literature

Consistent with our definitional guideposts, to analyze the digital platforms literature we first focused on a topical search initiated via Web of Science to identify articles containing the search term "digital platfor*." This initial search yielded a set of 3,515 scholarly articles. We then expanded this search to include "digital platform," and alternative keywords such as "digital platform ecosystem," "platform economy," "platform workers," "gig economy," "multisided platforms," "platform work," "sharing economy," and "platform capitalism" to provide a comprehensive set of articles that address fundamental themes in the overall literature. This expanded search yielded a total of 14,479 articles, which we narrowed down to 14,014 based on the accessibility of these articles for our review.

Key to any integrative review is the process of identifying and distilling all the material forms of homogeneity and heterogeneity across the existing literature. Toward this end, we used a set of machine learning algorithms (i.e., Word2Vec), which use natural language processing in the form of two-layer neural networks to analyze the semantic similarity of words in these studies. This analysis inductively provided us with two important insights to guide our review. First, we confirmed the central importance of "power" to the broader literature on digital platforms. Quite significantly, the cosine similarity score between "platform" and "power" is .215 while that for "platform" and "efficiency" is .162. Such scores indicate that while both sets of terms are relevant to the digital platforms literature, the broader social science literature focuses more on issues of power than efficiency.

The numerous implicit references to the role of power in existing reviews of the platforms, combined with our technical analyses of the broad digital platform literature, provide substantial analytical and technical support for our initiating premise that power dynamics are a central, but underexplored, topic in management research. In the following section, we build on this work to explore and analyze

how complex power dynamics shape important questions situated within the literature on digital platforms.

ACTORS, RELATIONS, FACES, AND POWER STRUGGLES: AN INTEGRATIVE REVIEW OF THE DIGITAL PLATFORMS LITERATURE

As an organizational form (McIntyre, Srinivasan, Afuah, Gawer & Kretschmer, 2021), digital platforms are in a state of continual flux (Peck & Phillips, 2020), with a rich array of business models (Periera, 2022) that bend and twist existing organizational structures into complex social matrices powered by opaque algorithmic forces (Gawer, 2022; Möhlmann, Zalmanson, Henfridsson & Gregory, 2021; Sutherland & Jarrahi, 2018; Townsend, Hunt, Rady, Manocha & Jin, 2023, 2024). Indeed, the growing diversity of digital platforms facilitates wide-ranging types of social and resource exchange (Frenken & Fuenfschilling, 2021), self-expression and exploration (Van Dijck, 2013), or advocacy and collective action (Dumitrica & Felt, 2020) that are only growing more complex with the advent of immersive digital environments such the metaverse (Fernandez & Hui, 2022). As platform owners strive to channel ever-larger swaths of individual lives onto digital platforms, the complexity of these social spaces with unclear governance arrangements, rooted in the struggle over rules and resources, challenges organizational scholars to analyze their precise role, impact, and purpose (Courpasson, 2017; Courpasson, Golsorkhi & Sallaz, 2012). These are elusive questions. Whatever else one might say about digital platforms, ultimately they are meta-organizations (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022)—comprised of varied actors (Chen, Yi, et al., 2022), relations (Schüßler et al., 2021), faces of power (Fleming & Spicer, 2014; Lukes, 1974), and struggle (Fleming & Spicer, 2007)—that are coordinated in ways and for reasons that question the very notion of efficient organizing. In the following sections, we explore the existing literature on each of these four dimensions.

Platform Actors: Owners, Complementors, Users, and Algorithms

Actors, meta-actors, informal power, and digital platforms. Existing research suggests that the motives, expectations, and actions of organizational actors are neither readily apparent nor simply stated. "The widespread assumption that organizations are groups of people working together to achieve a common goal is naïve," noted Fleming and Spicer (2007: 2); "all the evidence suggests that, though we work together at times, we also frequently work against each other (e.g. Pfeffer, 1981, 1992)." This may be particularly true of multisided digital platforms, where, despite the efficient orderliness that characterizes their outward-facing appearances, platform governance is, by design or accident, opaque, fractious, chaotic, and intensely asymmetric (Lewis, 2023). Ironically then, while there is a large body of work concerning the roles of platform stakeholders in promoting governance arrangements that optimize transactional efficiency (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022), comparatively little research has investigated how governance is shaped by their diverse interests, goals, objectives, susceptibilities, and political strategies (e.g., Blasco-Arcas, Alexander, Sörhammar, Jonas, Raithel & Chen, 2020; Heimburg & Wiesche, 2022; Van Alstyne & Parker, 2017).

Traditionally, scholars have sorted platform stakeholders into three broad categories: owners, complementors, and participant-users (Schreieck, Wiesche & Krcmar, 2016). In this section, we review existing research concerning these three groups as well as a new stakeholder category comprised of algorithmic agents. Table 2 provides definitional grounding for each.

The emerging conceptualization of digital platforms as meta-organizations (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022) is grounded in the notion that they function as "networks of firms or individuals not bound by authority based on employment relationships but characterized by a system-level goal" (Gulati, Puranam & Tushman, 2012: 575). Consistent with this view, existing literature depicts platform actors as network nodes, connected to and dependent upon the presence and action of others to create value through transactions that generate desired outcomes and resolve disputes (Chen et al., 2021). The limitation of this view is that stakeholders often pursue diverse goals under highly asymmetric conditions. Thus, as Van Dijck and colleagues (2019: 1) noted, scholars need to "shift attention from markets as level playing fields towards societal platform infrastructures where hierarchies and dependencies are built into their architecture." Doing so necessarily involves a comprehensive examination of the power wielded by all the actors comprising multisided digital platforms: participants, complementors, owners, and algorithms.

Participants, sometimes also referred to as "end users," are individuals who are motivated to use a digital platform for commercial or social benefit. The

TABLE 2
Types of Actors in the Digital Platforms Literature

Analytical Category	Subcategories	Definitions	Illustrative Examples
Actors	Owners	Actors who possess and attempt to maintain organizational control over the specialized assets used to create digital platforms (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022: 157–166)	Elon Musk's purchase of Twitter (now X) created a new, private digital platform controlled by a small number of operators and investors who enacted unilateral changes to the platform's digital architecture and operating practices
	Complementors	Heterogeneous, external actors who leverage the architectural affordances of digital platforms to supply "complementary" products and services (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022: 150 – 152)	Epic Games's lawsuit against the 30% fee Apple charges for all AppStore purchases highlights the challenges complementors face in offering goods and services through digital platforms
	Participants	Heterogeneous, external actors who consume or utilize products or services through digital platforms (Chen et al., 2021: 1306 – 1308)	Tumblr's decision to ban adult content led to more than a 30% decline in the number of users on the platform, causing the parent company to shut down most of the operations due to a failure to achieve advertising goals
	Algorithms	Heterogeneous, digital actors that shape the architectural affordances of digital platforms with varying degrees of human oversight (Rai, Constantinides & Sarker, 2019)	Backlash against OpenAI and other generative AI platforms by Getty Images and independent authors and artists illustrates the growing controversies over how algorithms are used by digital platforms to create and distribute content

sheer scale of this involvement is immense. By 2026, worldwide eCommerce is expected to approach $7 trillion (Ludmir, 2024). As of 2023, nearly six billion people belong to one or more platform-based social media networks with the average person visiting seven such sites at least once per month (Ludmir, 2024). Although participants are often thought of as consumers of platform-provisioned goods and services, their role is considerably more complex, since many digital platform owners rely upon participants to produce and post content, thereby giving rise to the notion of "digital prosumers,"[1] individuals who assist—and often take the lead—in producing the subject matter on the vast majority of digital platforms (Frenken & Fuenfschilling, 2021; Hendrikse et al., 2022; Komljenovic, 2021).

Complementors, meanwhile, are third-party individuals or entities who are independent of platform owners. They engage in activities that "spur generativity across the ecosystem, bringing the products and services offered to scope and scale, which are difficult to replicate within a single organization" (Engert, Evers, Hein & Krcmar, 2022). For example, the 10 million merchants selling goods and services on Amazon and the two million vendors on Shopify are eCommerce complementors. In the realm of social network platforms, an example of complementors is the 75,000 uncompensated individuals, known as "mods," who invest time, energy, and know-how into moderating Reddit's subreddit communities. In an interesting display of power emergence, an elite, though controversial, group of highly prolific and influential "super-mods" constitute a powerful subculture on Reddit, with six individuals moderating 118 of the top 500 subreddits (Ceci, 2024). Although complementors are often referred to as "autonomous actors," their ability to exert platform power is far from unimpeachable (Engert et al., 2022). While platform owners are reliant upon complementors in order to attract participants, build scale, generate revenue, spur growth, and fortify competitive sustainability (Jacobides, Cennamo & Gawer, 2018; Wan, Cenamor, Parker & Van Alstyne, 2017), platform owners keep a tight hold on the reins through the establishment and enforcement of "platform boundary resources" (PBR; Boudreau, 2010; Kannisto, Hästbacka & Marttinen, 2020), consisting of the tools that owners make available to complementors to interface with a platform and make it productive. Apple, for example, assiduously maintains control over PBRs for its various platforms—an approach that has resulted in frequent legal action by groups of complementors.

Owners. Although platform owners often directly produce very few goods and services, they control a great deal. As Hendrikse and colleagues (2022: 64)

[1] Or, more pejoratively, "digital serfs" (e.g., Fairfield, 2017).

asserted, "Big Tech"—by virtue of their platform ownership—is

> about control rather than ownership … for example by becoming the foundational infrastructure within a particular sector or service … In a self-reinforcing feedback loop, digital rent extraction is augmented by capitalizing upon "gatekeeper power, leveraging power, and information exploitation power" (Khan, 2018: 331).

This is an extension of the notion developed by Rahman and Thelen (2019: 4), who claimed that

> this "winner take all" market dominance offers many avenues for generating returns through rents while also multiplying the number of stakeholders whose dependence on the platform makes them potential allies in efforts to defend it against unwelcome regulation. This networked dominance is what makes platform firms both a revival and a reinvention of classical monopoly concern.

Historically speaking, the rise of platform ownership as a distinctive business model and organizational form is both mercurial and undeniably potent. "Digital platforms are," noted Sadowski (2020), "a nearly ubiquitous form of intermediary and infrastructure in society." The range of goods and services that can be procured, and the multitude of sociocultural network connections that can be accessed, are breathtaking in scope and impact. There are more than 26.5 million eCommerce sites and nearly as many social network platforms, ranging from cancer-survivor support groups to high school reunions, and from entrepreneurship clubs to terrorist organizations. The average platform participant routinely engages with scores of digital platforms. Yet, for all their ubiquity and impact, the power wielded by digital platform owners is notoriously opaque and unendingly controversial (Komljenovic, 2021; Lewis, 2023).

The rise of algorithms as digital platform actors. While previous literature on digital platforms and their governance has hewed closely to the participant–complementor–owner triumvirate, there is ample reason to expand this list to include digital agents (Rai et al., 2019) or micro workers (Tubaro, Casilli & Coville, 2020), particularly now that the era of generative AI—such as OpenAI's ChatGPT—is well upon us. The growing use of AI systems on digital platforms is fueling the rapid rise of hybrid modes of organizing through the construction of "human–machine networks" (Murray, Rhymer & Sirmon, 2021). In a growing number of cases, digital platform owners are deploying digital agents to govern, shape, influence, and control activity on their platforms (Agerfalk, 2020). Tasked with preventing the exchange of illegal content such as fraudulent schemes, child pornography, hate speech, and misinformation on digital platforms, efforts to automate content moderation continue to generate controversy as these automated tools still lack the nuance and sophisticated judgment of human actors (Udupa, Maronikolakis & Wisiorek, 2023). The onslaught of illegal content on digital platforms highlights the struggles these platforms face in balancing competing demands for open access and "free speech" while battling malicious "bot networks" intent on manipulating public discourse (Gorwa, Binns & Katzenbach, 2020; Zeng & Kaye, 2022).

The increasing preponderance of generative AI tools will amplify these problems as the "frictions" of malicious content production are eliminated, allowing malicious actors to flood digital platforms with nefarious content (Goldstein, Sastry, Musser & Sedova, 2023). Programming algorithmic control systems with the capacity for nuanced ethical judgment is still beyond the capabilities of most systems (Udupa et al., 2023). At the same time, certain aspects of these systems leave them vulnerable to adversarial attack as swarms of collective actors attempt to manipulate the algorithms to boost, promote, or distribute malicious content and messages (Madry, Makelov, Schmidt, Tsipras & Vladu, 2017). Researching the benefits and limitations of algorithmic control and governance will loom large as a critical topic of future research as digital platforms struggle to build and deploy digital agents that can address these problems.

Platform Relations: Mutuality, Autonomy, Control, and Adversaries

The networked structure of digital platforms provides an architecture for varied relationships among the stakeholder-actors that defies easy comparison with pre-digital organizations. For example, Heimburg and Wiesche (2022) aggregated data from 144 studies on platforms and identified *19* different kinds of relationships among owners, complementors, and end users. This suggests that, even though management scholars tend to emphasize a tripartite taxonomy of platform participant–complementor–owner actors,[2] the roles and motivations are often far more

[2] Consistent with other treatments of platform actors, Heimburg and Wiesche (2022) did not include algorithmic actors in their analysis. This is less a matter of consciously excluding the consideration of algorithms than it is a demonstration of AI's dizzying rate of change and the extent to which scholars are playing catch up.

TABLE 3
Relations in the Digital Platforms Literature

Analytical Category	Subcategories	Definitions	Illustrative Examples
Relations	Mutuality	Platform relationships that are defined by mechanisms of reciprocity and sharing among users and participants (Schüßler et al., 2021: 1221)	Artist boycotts of music streaming platform stem from conflicts over the distribution of music royalties between artists and platforms, and highlight power asymmetries
	Autonomy	Platform relationships that are defined by mechanisms of flexibility and independence (Schüßler et al., 2021: 1222)	Lawsuits surrounding driver pay on Uber and other mobility platforms center on whether drivers are autonomous contractors or employees of the platform
	Control	Platform relationships that are defined by mechanisms of dependence and asymmetries of information and power (Schüßler et al., 2021: 1223)	Amazon's control over web hosting via Amazon Web Services creates substantial information asymmetries between the platform and third-party sellers regarding sales trends on the platform
	Adversarial	Platform relationships that are defined by mechanisms of opposition and activism (Sadowski, 2020: 571; Van Dijck et al., 2019)	Microsoft's short-lived demo of the Tay chatbot highlights the susceptibility of algorithmic content generation and moderation to adversarial attack from external actors

fluid and diverse than the transactional relationships currently featured in most scholarly treatments of digital platforms (e.g., Chen, Tong, et al., 2022).

In this section, we build on Schüßler et al.'s (2021) typology of platform relationships, which consists of mutuality, autonomy, and control.[3] We expand this typology with a fourth type (which we call "adversarial"), and argue that the dynamic and often conflicting interplay between these different relations is central to understanding how digital platforms operate and evolve. Table 3 summarizes the four types of relations discussed in the literature on digital platforms.

Mutuality manifests through the principles of sharing and reciprocity (Khanagha, Ansari, Paroutis & Oviedo, 2022; Schüßler et al., 2021), which attract participants to platforms facilitating beneficial exchanges. Platforms like Airbnb and Uber exemplify this relationship, creating ecosystems where both service providers and users receive benefits—lodging and transportation services, respectively, are exchanged for payment in a reciprocal relationship that sustains each platform's relevance and utility. The principle of *autonomy*, characterized by freedom and independence (Esposito De Falco, Renzi, Orlando & Cucari, 2017), particularly appeals to complementors who contribute additional value to platforms, but can erode the autonomy of other actors, such as workers (Rahman, Weiss & Karunakaran, 2023). This tension is evident in the relationship between Apple's App Store and independent app developers. These developers leverage the platform to reach a wide customer base while enjoying the freedom to innovate within the technological framework provided by Apple. Although the platform exerts some level of control, it primarily serves as a facilitator that supports the developers' ability to operate independently. *Control*, as a relational dimension of platform governance, expresses explicit and implicit dependencies grounded in asymmetries related to a stakeholder's ability to influence decisions, actions, and outcomes (Schüßler et al., 2021). A prime example is Facebook's management of its news feed, which prioritizes certain types of content to influence user interaction and optimize ad revenue. This control extends beyond simple profit motives, impacting societal norms and individual privacy. Sadowski (2020) criticizes this approach, highlighting how the disproportionate benefits accrued by platforms often come at the expense of users' autonomy and privacy.

In channeling Foucault (1983), Fleming and Spicer (2014: 240) note that "power is achieved through defining the conditions of possibility underlying how people experience themselves as people and producing the type of people they think they naturally are." In a digital context, the process of defining these conditions is intensely complicated—a fact made more

[3] Schüßler et al. (2021) use the term "domination" when referring to the "exercise of power and control." To avoid confusion with our usage of "domination" as one of the four faces of power (i.e., coercion, manipulation, domination, and subjectification), we use the term "control" here.

pronounced by the relative opacity of the underlying relationships.

While digital platforms are a paragon of transactional efficiency (Täuscher & Laudien, 2018), their governance mechanisms are a blizzard of Rube Goldberg-esque twists and turns (Sadowski, 2020). Underneath the seldom-read terms and conditions, the public proclamations of rigorous oversight, and the extravagant claims of security and protection, digital platforms are potent power bases that are, at best, thinly understood by regulators (Papyshev & Chan, 2023) or even by the individuals who create and maintain them (Törnberg & Uitermark, 2020). Consequently, it appears to us that platform relationships are vastly more contentious than much of the existing management and organizational literature has noted—a point we delve into more deeply in the next section, which addresses the "faces" of platform power. Moreover, this contentiousness is likely to grow more acute (Hendrikse et al., 2022) as platform owners walk the narrow line between the protection and exploitation of complementors and user-consumers in their efforts to monetize the networks and loyalties of platform participation (Van Dijck et al., 2019). For this reason, we would add a fourth social relationship—which we have labeled *adversarial*—to Schüßler et al.'s (2021) troika of mutuality, autonomy, and control. Although much of the research on platform governance has examined these relational dimensions independently, they are more aptly considered as interlocking, cross-pollinating facets of the relationships spawned by digital platforms. We take up this interrelatedness in the following section.

From mutualism and autonomy to control and adversarial relations. In many respects, mutuality is the *raison d'être* of digital platforms. As web-based structural software, platforms are ultimately designed to connect people to ideas, information, products, services, resources, collaborators, kindred spirits, work, games, distractions, and often simply other people. Each year, more and more of our lives shift to involvement through platforms that have been built to connect us. Whether a site caters to a few hundred cancer survivors sharing stories, insights, and resources, or millions of online gamers, or tens of millions of people using JP Morgan Chase's online banking system, multisided digital platforms are predicated upon cocreative activities that are, at least ostensibly, intended to generate mutual benefits as the consequence of voluntary agreements between autonomous parties (Esposito De Falco et al., 2017).

Although a hallmark of multisided digital platforms is their unique ability to bring together heterogeneous participants to the mutual benefit of each, the platform business model necessitates keeping the relationships tightly linked to the platform (Harracá, Castelló & Gawer, 2023). Thus, much of the tension that is generated by the specific manner in which platforms offer autonomy and mutualism stems from the platforms' underlying desire to maintain control over the relationships they foster. Often, platform owners are incentivized to limit, control, and manipulate interactions between user groups in ways that serve the platform owner's objectives of user engagement and profitability. Although marketplace-type platforms present themselves as "matchmakers," in many cases the one-time event of finding a "match" is less profitable than permanently inserting the platform as a central forum for an ongoing relationship. For example, a dog-sitting platform does not want dog owners and dog sitters to form an ongoing relationship based on interpersonal trust, which may thrive outside the scope of the platform and thereby deprive the platform owner of future revenue opportunities. To maximize long-term revenue, the platform needs to control the relationship and ensure that participants continue to use platform-provided tools for search, payment, and performance evaluation. Platform participants, on the other hand, may prefer moving some of these activities beyond the purview of the platform—note, for instance, calls to tip gig workers in cash instead of through apps (De Stefano, 2016; Gandini, 2019; Glavin, Bierman & Schieman, 2021; Howcroft & Bergvall-Kåreborn, 2019; Kessler, 2018).

From the owner's perspective, platform relations involving mutuality and autonomy are only desirable to the extent that they generate cost-minimizing efficiencies. Too much mutuality or autonomy are anathema to platform survival; hence, adversarial control is a concomitant theme (Morgan & Nelligan, 2018). For instance, despite widespread rhetoric perpetuating myths of platform empowerment for gig workers and "micro-entrepreneurs" to act as their "own bosses," platform owners typically have strong incentives to capture participants through resource dependencies. Such arrangements preserve the power of platform owners over any private transactions between platform users, including the power to extract revenue (Gandini, 2019; Kessler, 2018). By commodifying the offerings on a platform, reducing worker autonomy, and tightly controlling information flows between platform participants, platform owners can turn participants (e.g., sellers and service

providers) into what Kuhn and Maleki (2017) dubbed "insta-serfs." Seen in this light, the recent push to introduce AI and, specifically, algorithmic decision-making to various aspects of platforms—such as pricing, route planning, content curation—can be interpreted not just as an effort to improve efficiency and coordination (Hendrikse et al., 2022; Rietveld & Ploog, 2022; Van Dijck et al., 2019) but also as a strategy to further commodify work. Conveniently, the same technologies that are supposed to maximize efficiency also serve to monitor, evaluate, and discipline gig workers (Curchod, Patriotta, Cohen & Neysen, 2020).

As we noted previously, existing research has largely emphasized owner-focused dyadic (or sometimes triadic) interactions between platform owners and participants of the platform (Gooty & Yammarino, 2010). This framing integrates pre-digital work on complex power dynamics among triads of actors as influencing organizational stability and effectiveness (Foucault, 1983; Heider, 1958; Huber, Kude & Dibbern, 2017; Madhavan, Gnyawali & He, 2004; Simmel, 1950). As the findings from our review illustrate (see Table 4), autonomy, mutuality, control, and opposition have each surfaced in the scholarly literature on platform governance. Yet, it is also apparent that key works in management and organizational research concerning platforms exhibit notable gaps concerning the ways in which platforms play host to a dense quagmire of complex, power-based relations, where there are almost always material tradeoffs in managing or governing digital platforms (e.g., Cennamo & Santallo, 2013; Parker, Van Alstyne & Choudary, 2016).

The reality is that, as it is exercised, platform governance involves many of the same human wants and needs as in the past, but without the relational transparency that characterized pre-digital marketplaces (Teh, 2022). Literature seeking to address this multilevel, multidirectional interplay of top-down and bottom-up forces is sparse (e.g., Rahman et al., 2024), but select works have taken steps to describe a "paradox of power and control" arising from the dynamic tension between the owner's need to retain control of platform outcomes by setting and enforcing macro-level platform rules, and their need to share enough power with other platform actors to incentivize growth and development at the micro level (De Reuver et al., 2018). This tension in the distribution of power between platform control and development affects how the platform provider addresses specific governance issues, including partitioning decision rights over transactions and applications, ownership of platform elements (proprietary vs. shared), controlling admission to the platform, and dispute resolution (Tiwana, 2013). Ultimately, the

TABLE 4
Faces of Power in the Digital Platforms Literature

Analytical Category	Subcategories	Definitions	Illustrative Examples
Faces	Coercion	A type of episodic power that is enacted for the purpose of getting an actor to do something they would have not done of their own accord (Fleming & Spicer, 2014: 242)	Metzger's (2024) publication of the "Twitter Files" purported to show the active coercion of the platform's content moderation practices by U.S. federal law enforcement agencies against conservative political figures or ideologies (e.g., COVID-19 political views)
	Manipulation	A type of episodic power that is enacted through agenda setting and the framing and shaping the perceptions of the importance of relevance of key issues (Fleming & Spicer, 2014: 242)	Controversies surrounding widespread election interference through the dissemination of disinformation on Meta's Facebook and other social media platforms highlights the risks digital platforms face in content moderation
	Domination	A type of systemic power that is instantiated through the reification of ideological values that shape actor preferences, attitudes, and beliefs (Fleming & Spicer, 2014: 243)	Political bans on TikTok in the United States and Europe mirror bans in China on U.S.-based social media platforms and are rooted in concerns regarding algorithmic promotion of ideological content
	Subjectification	A type of systemic power that is instantiated through the disciplinary practices that shape an actor's sense of self and identity (Fleming & Spicer, 2014: 244)	Apple TV's decision to cancel "The Problem with Jon Stewart" over his criticism of the Chinese Communist Party demonstrates the extent to which these platforms engage in self-censorship to protect valuable business relationships

platform owner remains the arbiter of governance decisions, implementing and enforcing mechanisms based on a strong platform identity and ownership stake (Chen, Yi, et al., 2022; Schreieck, Wiesche & Krcmar, 2018).

Taken together, our review of relations in digital platform governance underscores the complex ways relational ties and form shape the governance of digital platforms. As platforms owners struggle to maintain control over what participants can and cannot do on a digital platform, the very structure, purpose, and design of digital platforms undermines their use of either hierarchical or relational power (Kretschmer et al., 2022). Often, this leads to the emergence of adversarial relationships. For example, when platform owners "overplay their hand" and enact rules that are contrary to what users or participants find valuable, they face—often catastrophic—consequences (Bronstein, 2020; Williams & Mahmoud, 2017). Examples include Tumblr's ban of pornography leading to shedding tens of millions of users, and YikYak's requirement to add a phone number, eliminating anonymity and causing the company to shut down in 2017. Even Twitter (now known as X) has shed tens of millions of users because of users' disdain for the CEO (Elon Musk), changes in the monetization model, and being exposed to hateful or other types of unwanted content (Bump, 2023).

These anecdotes demonstrate that significant consequences befall digital platform owners who fail to understand the limits of control and the peril of an adversarial mindset. Thomas and colleagues (2021) conducted a detailed study of 27 highly adversarial attempts by users and complementors to stage "platform overthrows" in response to situations in which relational dynamics of autonomy and mutualism had succumbed to uncomfortable levels of control. We investigate this theme of struggle in the next section.

Faces of Platform Power: Coercion, Manipulation, Domination, and Subjectification

The heterogeneity of actors on digital platforms pursuing conflicting goals leverages different types of power, referred to as "faces" of power—a concept originally developed by Lukes (1974) and later drawn into management and organizational studies by Fleming & Spicer (2014). These faces include coercion, manipulation, domination, and subjectification (Fleming & Spicer, 2014)—each in the pursuit of strategic aims (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022). Anecdotal examples and scholarly works abound regarding how complex power dynamics, rooted in "algorithm-mediated forms of power" (Curchod et al., 2020) and digital architectures of algorithmic control (Burrell & Fourcade, 2021) empower and impinge upon strategic interests across the "contested terrain" of digital platforms (Kellogg, Valentine & Christin, 2020). Although organizational research often ignores or downplays power dynamics on digital platforms in favor of efficiency explanations, our analysis reinforces the notion that "power is everywhere" (Hurni, Huber & Dibbern, 2022). Recent studies on coercive gamification (Fitzpatrick & Marsh, 2022), algorithmic manipulation of news feeds (Greene, Martens & Shmueli, 2022), financial and structural domination (Hurni et al., 2022), and battles over ideological censorship (Cobbe, 2021) illustrate the various ways power dynamics manifest on digital platforms. Below, we document and analyze key topics relating to different faces of power in digital platform literature. Table 4 summarizes the key faces of power.

Coercion. Existing research defines coercive power as inducing someone to act (or not) in a way they would not have done on their own (Fleming & Spicer, 2014). Rooted in conflict, opposition, and control (Hurni et al., 2022), coercive power is a visible and widely studied type of power among the quartet identified by Fleming and Spicer (2014). Recent studies document the growing ways actors wield coercive power on digital platforms (Purcell & Brook, 2022). One emerging stream of research documents platform-based power rooted in resource dependencies (Miric, Boudreau & Jeppesen, 2019) used coercively by platform owners against complementors and users or participants (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021). Studies in "platform entrepreneurship" (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021) and "platform work" (Kenney, Bearson & Zysman, 2021) explore how platform owners coerce desired actions from complementors and users or participants (Chen, Yi, et al., 2022). For platform owners, coercive power is rooted in their ability to control access to valuable resources and opportunities under the guise of "incentives" (Ozalp, Cennamo & Gawer, 2018).

Although efficiency-oriented perspectives of digital platforms emphasize the role of incentives as mechanisms to coordinate actions and behaviors of complementors and participants or users (Boudreau & Jeppesen, 2015), power theorists argue that these incentives allow platform owners to control access to valuable customers and serve as "private regulators" determining acceptable actions on a digital platform (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021). Platform dependencies amplify threats, including "existential risks"

of demonetization or deplatforming based on unilateral decisions by owners (Rogers, 2020; Van Dijck, de Winkel & Schäfer, 2021). Despite research emphasizing "free entry and exchange" on digital platforms, the concentration of activities on a small number of platforms leaves marginalized actors with few options (Jhaver, Boylston, Yang & Bruckman, 2021). The ability to control access to valuable platform resources provides owners with coercive power to control actions and behaviors as they see fit. Studies explore the personal and financial problems created by demonetization and deplatforming for marginalized actors (Are & Briggs, 2023), controversial figures (Rogers, 2020), and other actors violating platform terms.

The coercive power of platform owners extends beyond managing access. Scholars document examples of how platform owners use coercion to elicit desired actions from complementors and users or participants (Chen, Yi, et al., 2022) by exploiting legally ambiguous regulations on employment contracts (Rogers, 2016), fair compensation (Nanda, Sankararaman, Dickerson & Srinivasan, 2020), job security (Lee, Huang & Ashford, 2018), product pricing, and design (Purcell & Brook, 2022). These coercive activities are aided by digital architectures wherein algorithms dictate terms through opaque governance, limiting participants' ability to engage other actors, including valuable customers (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021). Critics highlight the coercive influence of gamification systems on digital platforms, which increase productivity through automated challenges, feedback, and rewards (Gómez, 2019). Uber's use of gamification, rating systems, and congestion pricing continues to generate pushback from drivers (complementors) and scrutiny from regulatory agents (Calo & Rosenblat, 2017). As more platforms adopt gamification and algorithmic coercion (Bearson, Kenney & Zysman, 2019), ethical and organizational problems emerge (Thorpe & Roper, 2019), including questions about the fairness of resource distribution in winner-takes-all environments (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021).

Coercive power extends beyond owner-complementor, user, and participant relationships. Governments and institutional actors coerce owners, complementors, and users or participants on digital platforms (Earl, Maher & Pan, 2022) through digital surveillance and social control (Zuboff, 2022). Online mobs engage in ideological coercion to induce adherence to populist consensus through threats of resource withdrawal (Waisbord, 2020). Research documents and critiques these instances of coercive power, highlighting how digital platforms commodify coercive control. Critical questions remain about the role and impact of coercive power on digital platforms, which we explore further below. Our review shows that coercive power is crucial on digital platforms in ways scholars are only beginning to understand.

Manipulation. Similar to coercion, manipulative power is episodic, but it focuses on influencing, setting, or controlling discussion boundaries through "agenda setting" (Fleming & Spicer, 2014). Unlike coercion, manipulation occurs "in the background," using covert or indirect forms of control. Of the four power types identified by Fleming and Spicer (2014)—coercion, manipulation, domination, and subjectification—manipulative power surfaces most frequently in algorithmic systems of control (Ferrari & Graham, 2021). Enhanced by digital platforms' technological affordances (i.e., digital architectures that shape the range of possible or impossible actions; Ettlinger, 2018), manipulative power manifests through specific events and actions on platforms. Digital platform owners use manipulative power to shape how products, content, information, and choices are displayed (Susser, Roessler & Nissenbaum, 2019). Studies have shown how platforms like Facebook use "algorithmic behavioral modification" to manipulate user behaviors for the platform's benefit (Greene et al., 2022). Netflix employs similar algorithms to direct customers toward its proprietary content, enhancing its popularity while reducing interest in externally produced content.

Algorithmic manipulation also occurs at the platform level. Political and cultural figures allege that TikTok's algorithms promote political propaganda that undermines national interests (Su & Valdovinos Kaye, 2023). In response, political and regulatory bodies are considering or implementing bans on TikTok in specific regions. Although these bodies focus on platforms' use of algorithmic manipulation, such manipulation can also come from users. Microsoft's 2016 launch of the Tay chatbot illustrates this, as Reddit users manipulated the chatbot's algorithms to make misogynistic and racist comments (Dinan, Humeau, Chintagunta & Weston, 2019).

Advances in generative AI and other AI systems exacerbate these challenges by reducing barriers to creating malicious content. Contemporary machine learning algorithms lack "semantic awareness and understanding" (Townsend & Hunt, 2019; Townsend et al., 2023, 2024), making it difficult for content moderation algorithms to differentiate prohibited from permissible content (Gorwa et al., 2020). Malicious actors exploit these gaps in automated governance

systems on digital platforms. The prominence of algorithmic manipulation highlights new arenas of contestation on digital platforms. We outline avenues for future research to explore and analyze the role of manipulative power on digital platforms.

Domination. While coercive and manipulative power are episodic, domination and subjectification rely on structural power embedded in systems and social structures. Domination involves establishing influence through constructing ideological values that become hegemonic, shaping preferences, attitudes, and political outlooks (Fleming & Spicer, 2007, 2014). Domination is central to the platform economy, often manifesting through platform owners leveraging advantageous structural positions against complementors and users (Ploog & Nieborg, 2020; Schüßler et al., 2021). Platforms thrive on long-term relationships among platform ecosystem actors, seeking to lock in and use these relationships for their benefit (Schüßler et al., 2021).

Domination, like coercion, implicates resource dependencies and algorithmic affordances defining digital architectures. However, domination manifests through long-term relational ties among platform owners, complementors, and users (Rietveld & Schilling, 2021). Recent antitrust lawsuits in the United States illustrate platform owners' domination. In Google's recent antitrust trial, emails between Barry Diller, chairman of IAC, and Google executives revealed allegations of Google leveraging its platform dominance in competition-restricting ways. Diller expressed frustration with Google's punitive actions and policies that disadvantage other players that depend on a level playing field (Nylan & Alba, 2023). Numerous lawsuits focus on domination as the central legal contention point between complementors, users, and platform owners.

Domination shapes platform-dependent entrepreneurship and platform work by controlling prices (Cennamo, 2021), distribution (Vergne, 2020), customer relationships (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021), search visibility (Gawer, 2022), and other intermediating activities. Scholars in these research streams explore the risks of platform disintermediation for complementors and users, raising questions about the ideological dominance of free entry and exit on platforms (Chen, Yi, et al., 2022). Despite claims by platform owners about the freedom to exit platforms, monopolistic practices by a handful of successful platforms (Gala, Schwab & Mueller, 2024) have functionally reduced options (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021). Barry Diller's frustration with Google's dominance, such as raising prices without new benefits, reflects complementors' lack of viable alternatives. The ideological dominance of "free exchange" is perpetuated, often erroneously, by conflating platform exchange with free market exchange. Schüßler et al. (2021) argue that digital platforms extend beyond a hybrid organizational form, combining elements of hierarchies and markets into a unique synthesis of mutuality, autonomy, and domination. Our analysis indicates that domination is a central theme in digital platform research—one that is likely to become increasingly prominent, as evidenced by recent antitrust action by the U.S. government against Google (Grant, 2024).

Subjectification. While coercion, manipulation, and domination have been explored in digital platform literature, comparatively few studies focus on subjectification. Subjectification is "achieved [by] defining the conditions of possibility underlying how we experience ourselves as people. Power, therefore, produces the kind of people we feel we naturally are" (Fleming & Spicer, 2007: 23). This deep level of influence affects individuals' sense of self, emotions, and identity. According to Fleming and Spicer (2014), subjectification shapes the essence of who people are, influencing self-perception and social roles, but through means and methods that often escape the attention of those who are controlled. Although critics of social media platforms decry the ability of these platforms to manipulate users' perceptions and interactions, accelerating problems of online polarization are at least partially a consequence of user behaviors and preferences (Woodcock & Johnson, 2018; Zuboff, 2022).

Yet, occupying "safe spaces" is only one part of the platform struggle. Here, too, subjectification surfaces through acts of self-censorship as individuals selectively constrain opinions, beliefs, and expectations in order to conform to those espoused by their ideological compatriots. Numerous studies document how social media influencers and personalities, political leaders, corporate executives, and everyday users self-censor their expressed views and opinions on digital platforms for fear of being criticized or cancelled (Woodcock & Johnson, 2018). In this sense, subjectification differs from manipulation because individuals appear to be "doing it to themselves." While such conformity and social control are achieved through both psychological and cultural mechanisms, the process of subjectification often manifests through personal efforts to craft online personas that align with popular content types, internalizing these norms as part of their social identity.

Gamification and rating systems on digital platforms also play a role in subjectifying users and participants (Graham, 2018; Uysal, 2023). As users strive to achieve high ratings and gamified performance objectives, they often willingly choose to subordinate their primary goals to those of the platform owners (Woodcock & Johnson, 2018). Algorithms control the distribution of rewards, incentivizing and manipulating users to act in the platform owners' best interests. Studies highlight problems created by "algorithmic management" for users and participants, including concerns about constant surveillance and algorithm opacity (Möhlmann et al., 2021; Vasudevan & Chan, 2022). Users feel they are at a constant disadvantage on a digital battleground where their behaviors are scrutinized, analyzed, manipulated, and controlled (Zuboff, 2022). Despite concerns about the loss of agency, some studies show transnational "third-space subjectification" processes where users, particularly women, express ideologies challenging local patriarchal systems and neoliberal ideologies (Dippner, 2018; Errázuriz, 2021; Hurley, 2022).

Subjectification processes also occur at the platform level. Apple's removal of "The Problem with Jon Stewart" due to planned political content about China highlights the tension between complementors and platform owners. This decision, attributed to "creative conflicts," suggests that self-censorship is used to protect business relationships from political pressure (Mullin, Kobln & Mickle, 2023). Digital platforms face pressure from political and regulatory agents for political and social surveillance (Zuboff, 2022). The possibility of digital surveillance induces most users to self-censor politically sensitive speech (Cobbe, 2021), and platforms face pressure to censor controversial political activities and speech. In the United States, threats to remove Section 230 protections, which provide social media platforms with broad immunity from liability for user activities, have increased pressure on these platforms to censor controversial political content.

Overall, although digital platform research has not extensively explored subjectification, existing studies highlight its importance. We further examine conflicts between the emancipatory possibilities of digital platforms and the role of subjectification in constraining the activities of users, complementors, and platform owners.

Platform Power Struggles: Refusal, Voice, Escape, and Creation

The confluence of complex power dynamics on digital platforms fuels acts of resistance and struggle that reflect broader trends in organizational research concerning the role of power (Medzini, 2022; Sybert, 2022). On digital platforms, complex power relations among owners, complementors, participants, and algorithms manifest in full-blown acts of resistance and outright struggle, where users and complementors rise up to resist unilateral actions enacted by platform owners (Ricart et al., 2020). Across the literature on power struggles among owners, complementors, and participants, existing research surfaces several important topics and themes that exemplify the complex ways power and acts of resistance are enacted on digital platforms: refusal, voice, escape, and creation. We explore these themes in the digital platform literature below. Table 5 summarizes the forms of struggle we analyze.

Refusal. To contravene the pernicious impacts of coercion, actors engage in acts of refusal to challenge how tasks are undertaken and pursued (Fleming & Spicer, 2007). In the realm of digital platforms, acts of refusal often manifest in efforts by complementors to resist an owner's ability to impose decisions on stakeholders. Digital platform infrastructures are vulnerable to participant-led attacks when users possess the requisite knowledge and are at least minimally coordinated. In a fashion similar to the tactics of saboteurs and Luddites in bygone eras, platform participants seeking to contest owner governance act covertly and subversively by pursuing alternative goals, sabotaging systems to decrease platform value, promulgating false reviews, issuing threats, and engaging in digital ransom (Haz, Acaro, Guzman, Espin & Molina, 2019; Wang, Zamudio & Jewell, 2023).

The potency of these various acts is strengthened by the emergence of digital solidarity, amplifying the tensions inherent in normative questions of *how* actors wield coercive power (Benkler, 2016; Forte, Larco & Bruckman, 2009; Konieczny, 2010). Ultimately, platform participants are the source of much of the value created and captured by platform owners. As such, they have more potential control over the means of production than do platform employees, or even pre-digital employees (Bridoux & Stoelhorst, 2022), which, when collectively organized, has the potential to counterbalance owner power (Ricart et al., 2020). In a process similar to that characterizing the rise of organized labor unions in the pre-digital setting, digital solidarity among users plays an important role in contesting governance decisions by owners.

In an interesting twist that fully leverages web-based digitalization, several studies (e.g., Karanović, Berends & Engel, 2021; Kuhn & Maleki, 2017) have highlighted the potential for platform participants to

TABLE 5
Power Struggles in the Digital Platforms Literature

Analytical Category	Subcategories	Definitions	Illustrative Examples
Power struggles	Refusal	Acts of resistance in response to coercive power that challenge how tasks are either undertaken or pursued in a manner that is different than those specified by other actors (Fleming & Spicer, 2007: 32–35)	The "John Oliver Protest" by Reddit content moderators who opposed the platform's changes to the pricing model for third-party apps to access the site's data. Content moderators removed filters on adult content and flooded the platform with pictures of the media personality John Oliver as the *de facto* symbol of the resistance
	Voice	Acts of resistance in response to manipulative power that challenges or disrupts the systemic silencing of issues by other actors (Fleming & Spicer, 2007: 35–38)	The Etsy seller strike enacted in protest of the payment reserves system that required external sellers to maintain up to 75% of their earnings for up to 90 days, which sellers argued "failed the transparency test by providing zero details or actionable information" (Diaz, 2022) in the platform's communications of these top-down changes
	Escape	Acts of resistance enacted in response to dominating power that manifests when groups try to change the goals imposed by other actors (Fleming & Spicer, 2007: 38–41)	Backlash from adult content creators on OnlyFans in response to the platform's decisions to ban adult content reflect ongoing conflicts between platform owners who are facing external pressure from advocacy groups and content creators who use the platform to connect with their audience
	Creation	Acts of resistance enacted in response to subjectification that challenge attempts by other actors to control the means of identity construction (Fleming & Spicer, 2007: 41–45)	Truth Social launched in the wake of censorship controversies against conservative politicians and viewpoints on mainstream social media platforms

leverage *other* platforms—such as online forums and social media—as a means to share information and organize resistance to platform owners' power. Examples of platform participants contesting owner-imposed governance in novel ways include recent seller "strikes" in response to new rules on Etsy (Diaz, 2022), user-driven shutdowns of thousands of message boards on Reddit to protest changes to Reddit's monetization model (Levenson, 2023), coordinated fake product reviews on Amazon, and attacks on the reputation of social platforms like X by bot networks that amplify misinformation. Across these and numerous other examples, acts of refusal play an important role in the struggles against coercive power. We return to these questions below to highlight several important avenues for future research.

Voice. In response to manipulative power, actors use voice in the struggle to resist the systemic silencing of issues and perspectives of other actors on digital platforms. Voice is aided in meaningful ways "through the support which these force relations find in each other" (Foucault, 1983: 92)—what Foucault describes as the chaining together of force relations, culminating in the emergence of digital solidarity. Recognizing the power of collective voice on digital platforms—what some commentators derisively label as "slacktivism" (Morozov, 2009)—illuminates important ways in which voice is expressed on digital platforms.

In some cases, digital platforms are the medium of digital organizing—and, contrary to the slacktivist label, using digital platforms to organize and coordinate voice appears to be generating real-world consequences. Recent changes to the terms and conditions of Reddit that users perceived would sideline numerous third-party apps and limit the ability of volunteers to effectively moderate the communities they manage led to the "John Oliver Protest," where content moderators allowed users to flood the platform with memes containing pictures of the TV personality John Oliver (Fung, 2023). In this case, Reddit moderators and users chained together the voices of "old media" and "new media" by recruiting Oliver to leverage his platform on broadcast media to criticize and resist the unilateral actions of Reddit managers. Such forms of creative protest, which technically do not violate the terms and conditions of the digital platform, represent an alternative approach for chaining together "force relations" to leverage collective action to refuse the imposition of the goals of platform owners to be implemented on the platform.

Escape. Actors use escape in the struggle to resist the use of domination in organizations (Fleming & Spicer, 2007). Recent studies in the digital platform literature illuminate several ways in which different actors use escape in response to attempts by platform owners to dominate other actors through the enforcement of changes to existing operating norms and conditions. The collective resistance from high-profile user and participant rebellions—akin to what Thomas and colleagues (2021) have labeled "platform overthrows"—have become more frequent, evidenced by the rapid unraveling of high-profile platforms such as Twitter and OnlyFans. In these and other instances, vociferous resistance to top-down enforcement of owner-mandated changes to the terms and conditions highlight the importance of examining these platforms as a context of collective resistance—capable of not just resisting unilateral change but also perpetuating and advancing the collective interests of users and participants (e.g., Bella & Beacham, 2021).

Escape plays out in complex ways in response to domination. Keith Gill and his so-called army of "apes" coordinated an aggressive stock-buying scheme on Reddit's subreddit group "r/WallStreetBets" to generate a short squeeze on large hedge funds that had built highly leveraged positions shorting GameStop stock (Verlaine & Banerji, 2021). To enact their strategy, the apes coordinated their efforts by "chaining together" two different digital platforms—Reddit to coordinate their meme-stock strategy, and the digital investment platform Robinhood to enact their strategy. These coordinated actions of the meme-stock revolution of the apes (i.e., "apes together strong") generated enormous pressure on several large hedge funds, resulting in millions of dollars of losses for these investors. Digital platforms provided an alternative medium for a "small army" of investors to bypass existing power structures in the finance industry—in a clear sense to "escape" from the constraints imposed by hegemonic incumbents.

Creation. Actors use creation in response to the subjectification processes (Fleming & Spicer, 2007). In prior research, creation is described as acts of resistance that challenge attempts by other actors to control the means of identity construction (Fleming & Spicer, 2007). Acts of creation from complementors and users highlight the complex ways in which the notion of "self-governance" plays out on digital platforms. Törnberg and Uitermark (2020: 6) express the essence of these governance "doubters," writing:

> we scrutinize the theoretical and political notion of "self-organization" and unpack its idealistic connotations: To what extent does self-organization actually imply empowerment or freedom? Who is the "self" in "self-organization," and who is the user on urban digital platforms? Is self-organization necessarily an expression of the interests of the constituent participants?

The struggle over identity in the context of digital platforms is highly apropos since platform users are not formal members or employees of the platform as organization; rather, they are independent actors not compelled to participate on the platform (Cusumano, 2020; Gawer, 2022). This identity distinction (i.e., owner vs. users) creates a space for determining governance that incorporates both the economic and social dimensions of platform governance. This suggests that platform participants, as contributors to platform value creation outside the formal structure of the owning firm, have power and leverage to influence platform governance decisions. This leverage and power arguably better describe the position of buyer or consumer participant types than sellers or creators on platforms (Cutolo & Kenney, 2021).

The use of creation as acts of resistance and struggle against the power of subjectification increasingly manifests through what some might perceive to be acts of social deviance on digital platforms. The rise of digital provocateurs, outrage farming, "shitposting," and subversive parody accounts illustrate a vast array of creative struggles of actors against stifling norms of self-censorship. In these cases, the goal is often to provoke outrage and flaunt an explicit rejection of prevailing ideological norms and rules. An even more aggressive act of resistance occurs when actors create entirely new digital platforms and spaces with alternative norms and rules of conduct that are more aligned with their ideological interests. Algorithms themselves can sometimes be the battleground in acts of resistance on digital platforms. The creation of bot networks highlights the complex ways in which acts of resistance play out on digital platforms. As platforms experiment with new approaches to combat these threats, research exploring how digital rights and responsibilities emerge and are utilized by different groups will undoubtedly reveal new, hybrid approaches that draw on different political governance models for inspiration but are adapted in important ways to the unique challenges of building sustainable digital environments.

FUTURE RESEARCH AT THE INTERSECTION OF COMPLEX POWER DYNAMICS AND DIGITAL PLATFORMS

Our thematic and integrative analysis of the current digital platform literature points to the need for

a vastly wider aperture for future research on the complex role of power dynamics on digital platforms. Toward this end, we critically assessed four key dimensions—actors, relations, faces, and struggle—to identify important and emerging themes and topics in the literature as a basis to outline future research opportunities at the intersection of power and digital platforms. Management and organizational scholars can, and should, play a more pronounced role in contributing to this multidisciplinary pursuit. With this aim in mind, we propose a multilevel, multidirectional approach to future research for the digital platform literature.

Rentier Platforms—Profiting from the Intermediation of Everyday Life

The ubiquity of digital platforms is a testament to their unmatched ability to minimize the search costs of users and complementors (Chen et al., 2021). Whether the intention is to ease the process of finding a partner, catch up with friends and family, arrange accommodations halfway around the world, harvest the recent equity market gossip, or secure the last remaining snow shovel, two-sided and multisided platforms are marvels of efficiency (Salutina, Platunina & Vasileva, 2021)—disregarding for a moment the costs associated with misinformation—whose reach and influence are steadily accelerating through the use of both supervised and autonomous algorithm-based agents (Nitzberg & Zysman, 2022). The problem—for both scholars and platform stakeholders—is that digital platforms have spawned new forms of domination (Meyer, Schaupp & Seibt, 2019), many of which are extraordinarily difficult to identify and contest (Van Dijck et al., 2019), thereby placing ethical power at risk of exploitative practices (Schüßler et al., 2021).[4]

Fundamentally, platforms are infrastructural forms of intermediation. Historically, intermediation of this sort has been financially rewarded. For instance, the owners of assets such as brick-and-mortar shopping malls, farmland for sharecropping, cellular towers, stock exchanges, and commercial satellites have traditionally extracted rents from users as payment for access to or use of these assets. While the "rentier capitalism" (e.g., Andreucci et al., 2017; Christophers, 2020, 2020; Dal Maso, Robertson & Rogers, 2021; Sadowski, 2020) associated with these valued assets is generally well understood—if not always admired (Christophers, 2021; Morozov, 2016)—the rents extracted from users and complementors of digital platforms are considerably less clear than they were in the pre-digital era (Christophers, 2020). Digital rents are extremely lucrative. Since 2008, the value of tech stocks has climbed from 16% of the overall market capitalization to nearly 60% in 2023 (Ludmir, 2024). Thus, while much of the management and organizational literature on digital platforms has sought to apply extant theories of transactional efficiency to the study of platform governance, a more thorough reckoning of the power dynamics and governance structures characterizing digital platforms requires understanding how rents are extracted through the platform-based intermediation of our everyday lives (Barns, 2019; Perzanowski & Schultz, 2016). Sadwoski (2020: 568) refers to this evolving rentier landscape as an "internet of landlords," wherein:

> the rentier model hinges on the platform becoming a (necessary) intermediary in the production, circulation, or consumption process. The platform's owner, due to their control over access to the "condition or means of production", can then "exact a tribute" from all economic activity that includes their property. (Harvey, 2006: 73)

Although the scaling of digital platforms occurs organically, suggesting the emergence of a flat, democratizing landscape (Langley & Leyshon, 2017) populated with cocreating participants and complementors, platform owners exercise all four forms of power—coercion, manipulation, domination, and subjectification (Fleming & Spicer, 2014)—in orchestrating the extraction of rents across all four relational subdimensions—mutuality, autonomy, control, and adversarial (Fields, 2022; Schüßler et al., 2021)—through the use of mechanisms designed to bind participants to platforms, extract their data, and monetize their online presence (Mezzadra & Neilson, 2015). Even social media platforms, several of which are among the most valuable companies in the world, extract rents by requiring "payments in attention, information, or affiliation," which are sold to "advertising companies and market researchers" (O'Dwyer, 2015: 234; see also Langley & Leyshon, 2017).

For management and organizational scholars, the relative quiescence on the power dynamics of platform governance and the emergence of a new rentier capitalism has grown conspicuous. Going forward, the Academy has an opportunity to provide much-

[4] We thank the associate editor for his detailed insights concerning how best to frame this critical area for future research.

needed insights concerning the managerial and organizational impacts of rentier platforms. In particular, scholars may ask: What are the implications of the power exercised to extract platform-based rents (Mezzadra & Neilson, 2017) for issues of equity, autonomy, and self-pursuit? As more and more firms cast themselves as "platform-based organizations," what are the implications for stakeholder well-being and corporate social responsibility? The sheer complexity and opacity (Crain, 2018) of the ways in which platform owners extract rents requires scholars to assess whether extant theories of firm boundaries and top management team ethics sufficiently address rentier business models. Scholars also need to move swiftly to assess the extent to which AI-enabled platform actors may exacerbate opacity and complexity beyond the reach of effective governance. The nature and substance of rentier–participant relationships, particularly in the metaverse, may reveal diminished accountability and exponentially higher value extraction (Buana, 2023; Cox, 2022; Crain, 2018).

As digital platforms situate themselves as intermediaries at the crossroads of an ever-increasing array of the activities, the inequitable distribution of value to various platform actors will instigate cycles of political struggle and conflict (Piketty, 2014).

Proposition 1. Increasing levels of "rentier capitalism" manifested through the concentration of ownership and control will increase the likelihood of political conflict on digital platforms.

Gig Economy, Gig Workers, and Digi-Serfs

As the foregoing discussion of rentier platforms suggests, management and organizational scholars face both challenges and opportunities in contending with the pervasive intermediation of digital platforms in everyday life (Barns, 2019; Harvey, 2006; Perzanowski & Schultz, 2016). From a governance perspective, notes Sadowski (2020: 568), this means that the power wielded by platform owners "is simultaneously distributed and centralized. It spreads rentier relations far and wide, at different scales and intensities, while also concentrating control over the system and value captured from the system in a small number of large hands." From a scholarly perspective, this poses a number of difficulties for existing theories of the firm because digital platforms, and the power they wield, have no clear parallel among pre-digital technologies, business models, and organizational forms. Scholars outside the management field have been far more vigorous in conducting investigations of this sea change. Vallas and Schor (2020: 273–274), for example, asserted in their review of labor platforms that,

> platforms represent a distinct type of governance mechanism, different from markets, hierarchies, or networks, and therefore pose a unique set of problems for regulators, workers, and their competitors in the conventional economy… These include systemic relations between traditional firms and platforms, the role of platform designers and managers, possibilities of collective action by platform workers, and the struggle over the regulatory regime that will govern platforms.

Nowhere are these challenges more evident than in the changing nature of work arising through the rapid growth and continuing evolution of the gig economy. For these reasons, platform intermediation in the realm of human labor poses a special set of issues concerning the power dynamics of platform governance (Schor, 2020).

Vallas and Schor (2020) identify five overlapping categories of gig-economy labor: (1) architects and technologists of the platforms; (2) cloud-based consultants or freelancers; (3) workers whose services are engaged via platforms and generally performed offline; (4) individuals engaged in micro-task functions that computers cannot yet perform; and (5) unpaid laborers working in "the penumbra of social media," including content producers and influencers (Duffy, 2017). For the less skilled among these workers, the gig economy has brought a mixed array of impacts (Koppel & Kolencik, 2018), reigniting contingent labor debates dating back to the 1990s (e.g., Matusik & Hill, 1998). For example, some scholars have heralded the heightened level of flexibility and entrepreneurial spirit labor platforms provide workers (Brynjolfsson & McAfee, 2014; Einav, Farronato & Levin, 2016; Parker et al., 2016), while others have argued that gig work has fundamentally disabled the structured set of rights that have historically been accorded workers (Harvey, 2006; Vallas, 2019), and that the romanticized notion of a gig economy unleashing millions of micro-entrepreneurs (Van Doorn, 2017) is actually an "accelerant to precarity" (Kalleberg, 2009, 2013; Kalleberg & Vallas, 2017; Vallas & Prener, 2012)—reminiscent of what Pugh (2015) called "the tumbleweed society" of individuals futilely attempting to confront persistent insecurity.

Many gig workers essentially function as a mechanism for platform owners to offload operational risk, while still extracting intermediation rents (Schor, 2016). For example, ridesharing and delivery

platforms such as Door Dash, Lyft, Uber, and a host of others sidestep the purchase of expensive, depreciable assets, while leveraging the flexibility of human assets that do not have to carried on the corporate books as the firms' employees (Schor & Attwood-Charles, 2017). Laborers internalize costs normally borne by the firm, leaving the platform owners enriched but workers generally without anchored recourse in difficult times. Rent-seeking platform owners appear to be largely ineffectual to these developments (Törnberg & Uitermark, 2020). For example, Amazon founder Jeff Bezos—one of the world's largest digital platform owners—has referred to Amazon Mechanical Turk, the microwork platform started by his company, as being a business proffering "humans-as-a-service" (Sadowski, 2020). The promises of autonomy and mutuality often appear to be eclipsed by the realities of control and adversarial engagement (Van Dijck et al., 2019)—a condition that critics have disparagingly labeled the advent of "digi-serfs" (Birch, 2020: Fairfield, 2017; Harvey, 2010; Marshall, 2021; Taylor, 2014). Compounding the challenges, recent scholarship suggests that the fate of gig workers is likely to worsen through the increasing deployment of AI (Fairfield, 2017: Morozov, 2016; Vallas & Schor, 2020), fueling indiscriminate market entry and extreme levels of small firm failure—a condition Hunt (2015) labeled "contagion entrepreneurship."

In substantive fashion, management scholars have been active in assessing the changing nature of work (e.g., Burke & Ng, 2006; Graeber, 2018), including a concerted effort to characterize and frame the implications of the gig economy (Mehta, 2023; Schor, 2016); however, as our review revealed, very little scholarship has examined these issues through the lens of power dynamics and digital platform governance. Here, too, there are a number of conceptual and empirical avenues that would be uniquely enriched by more and better management research, such as: How have platforms-as-labor-intermediaries changed the nature of work? What are the specific drivers of autonomy or control for each of the five categories of gig workers identified by Vallas and Schor (2020)? When, why, and how are platform owners able to concentrate power with some worker groups, but not others? How have platforms contributed to the improvement or diminution of equity and worker well-being? For those workers disadvantaged by digital platform governance, is the situation recoverable, or does it appear that the "shipped has sailed?" As Thomas and colleagues (2021) intimated, can there be "platform overthrows?" Are there policy cures or collective actions that might address disadvantageous power dynamics? Are there technological remedies to persistent power imbalances? Will the use of AI increase or decrease competitive dynamics for gig labor, and with what results?

Overall, the plight of gig workers on digital platforms reinforces the fundamentally important role of resource dependencies as a critical source of power asymmetries among actors on digital platforms. For gig workers and other platform-dependent actors, their degree of platform dependency provides platform owners with more leeway and power to reshape these relational ties. Without the ability to work in concert with others, such dependencies increase the likelihood gig workers and other platform-dependent workers are subjected to extractive relationships on these platforms.

Proposition 2. The degree of alienation between platform actors will amplify the likelihood that platform-dependent actors are subjected to extractive relationships on digital platforms.

The Emancipatory Possibilities of Digital Platforms

As suggested from the outset, neither the vilification nor the valorization of digital platforms is a singularly useful perspective. The ubiquitous presence and transformative impact of platforms in the era of *homo digitalis* (Montag & Diefenbach, 2018) suggests that there is an unquenchable appetite for the benefits emanating from digital platforms and that the perceived utility of platforms is palpable. These perceptions and impacts are also germane to future study by management scholars. Even while acknowledging the subjugating specter of rentierism and digi-serfs, management scholars can play a key role in clarifying and assessing the perceived payoffs to platform participants, including the numerous dimensions that extend beyond the well-established, TCT-based case for transactional efficiency (e.g., Chen, Yi, et al., 2022). Despite their various maladies, digital platforms have facilitated significant growth in communication, information, knowledge, human capital, ideological, emotional, and cultural exchange all around the world (Adner, Puranam & Zhu, 2019; Kretschmer et al., 2022; Täuscher & Laudien, 2018). These impacts pave the way for numerous emancipatory possibilities, through the introduction of new power structures and alternative norms (Brynjolfsson & McAfee, 2014; Einav et al., 2016; Parker et al., 2016).

The emancipatory possibilities of digital platforms refer to the empowerment of individuals and groups

to exercise greater agency, freer expression, and relatively unencumbered access to resources and opportunities—all of which are enabled through the democratizing nature of digital technologies. This contrapuntal perspective offers a far more optimistic view of the digital platform power dynamics. As Zarkadakis (2022: 112) asserted, "Just as the printing press was a catalyst for decentralized knowledge, so too with blockchains we now have the possibility to circumvent the incumbent feudal lords of data and AI." Thus, juxtaposed alongside Sadowski's (2020) "internet of landlords" is hope for the "emancipatory potential of digital technologies" (Hassan, Mir & Khan, 2023: 4170; see also McAdam, Crowley & Harrison, 2019). Such emancipation encompasses various dimensions, including, but not limited to, intellectual pursuits, emotional and biological needs, ideological expression, and varied lifestyles. It entails the expansion of choices, capabilities, and forms of collaboration beyond traditional boundaries, allowing individuals to transcend geographical, social, and institutional limitations (Durkheim, 1982). Emancipation also involves the ability to challenge and circumvent monopolistic control over content, distribution, and participation, fostering greater autonomy and self-determination, by upending the structural asymmetries of power (Meyer et al., 2019). "Let us imagine," proposed Zarkadakis (2022:111), "that, instead of letting a small minority enjoy the bountiful rewards of an automated future, we claim that future for ourselves too."

There is a great need for management scholars to broaden and deepen their exploration of when, how, and why *homo digitalis* may find emancipatory potential in digital platforms. For instance, the "world-flattening" (Friedman, 2005) impacts of a free and flowing exchange of intellectual insights enables the emergence of heretofore impossible forms of collaboration, ranging from cross-border cures for crowd-sourced diagnoses of medical conditions to the Arab Spring uprisings in the early 2010s, and from cutting-edge design consortia to cross-border solutions to the childcare crises in Europe and the United States. Platforms have also proved to be instrumental in addressing labor shortages in one locale by connecting firms in need of labor with unemployed workers in other locales (Kalleberg, 2009, 2013; Koppel & Kolencik, 2018). In this fashion, individuals such as software developers and digital marketers can find remote work opportunities to better monetize their intellectual capital through work that is sourced on demand via multisided digital platforms. Platforms have also provided emancipatory relief to religious groups and activists seeking coordination and collective expression with less fear of oppression or reprisals (Evolvi, 2021). In still other respects, individuals are able to embrace lifestyle preferences with a greater degree of privacy and broadened scope of personal access. For example, adult video creators can use digital platforms such as OnlyFans to release their content in a manner that bypasses monopoly producers who otherwise control content and distribution (Tiidenberg, 2021).

Future research concerning these, and other, emancipatory benefits will assist scholars, practitioners, and policymakers in better understanding the optimal lines of demarcation in digital platform governance. The nuanced tradeoffs between liberating access and expression, on the one hand, and the monetization of data harvesting and privacy breaches, on the other hand, are important lines of inquiry for future research. Moving forward with a stronger grounding in the power dynamics of digital platforms, scholars can ask: When, how, and why will participants and complementors knowingly or unknowingly accede to the power of platform owners? Under what conditions is doing so prudent, beneficial, or even rational? Micro theorists may ask: Are there circumstances in which individuals may be better off intellectually, emotionally, biologically, religiously, ideologically, or mentally even with subjectification by platform owners? How will the escalating reliance by platform owners on algorithmic actors influence the reasons that platform participants engage in platform activities despite severely asymmetric power dynamics? Individuals, liberated from the structural constraints of their respective local environments, may be willing to accept coercion, manipulation, domination, and subjectification, in exchange for a latent utility function that scholars of management and organizations would do well to investigate and illuminate.

Ultimately, the emancipatory potential of digital platforms will hinge on the degree to which platforms enable or constrain actors to generate novel relational ties with other actors. Although platform owners promulgate the "free-entry, free-exchange" discourse, the structural flexibility of digital network infrastructures cuts both ways. Platform actors can often enter or exit at will, but so too can platform owners alienate and control how these actors engage with others. Thus, even as platforms generate self-congratulatory praise for their ability to "connect the world," examples abound of how platforms can

disintermediate and disconnect actors in ways that constrain the emancipatory power of these platforms.

Proposition 3. The emancipatory potential of digital platforms will be positively related to the degree to which actors are permitted to create novel relational ties with other actors.

Intelligent Algorithms as Platform Actors

In examining the intricate power structures of digital platforms, we have asserted that reality now necessitates the recognition that algorithms are active participants, not simply passive tools or background forces. This approach does not ascribe human qualities to algorithms but illuminates crucial questions about their evolving impact on platform ecosystems. The multifaceted nature of algorithmic influence is well-documented (Townsend et al., 2023, 2024). They serve as managerial control mechanisms, allowing platform owners to oversee and guide user and complementor behaviors (Chen, Yi, et al., 2022). Simultaneously, algorithms shape the digital landscape, crafting affordances that both enable and restrict certain actions (Ettlinger, 2018). In some instances, they become contested spaces, redistributing influence among platform stakeholders (Elkin-Koren, 2020).

A relational perspective to platforms (Bailey, Faraj, Hinds, Leonardi & von Krogh, 2022) reveals a more nuanced reality. The interplay between algorithms and human actors is yielding unexpected outcomes, fostering new forms of agency (Murray et al., 2021) and hybrid intelligences (Rai et al., 2019). As algorithms grow in sophistication and autonomy (Townsend & Hunt, 2019; Townsend et al., 2023), a critical question emerges: How does this evolution reshape the power landscape of digital platforms? For platform owners, intelligent algorithms offer enhanced means of influence. They can address challenges like the "cold start" problem with new users, gradually building comprehensive profiles that strengthen platform dependencies (Vomberg, Schauerte, Krakowski, Bogusz, Gijsenberg & Bleier, 2023). This data accumulation amplifies the owners' power base, making it increasingly difficult for users to disengage. Yet, this same technology empowers users and complementors in unprecedented ways. It enables novel forms of resistance, amplifying acts of refusal, voice, creation, and exit. The rapid ascent of TikTok, driven by its highly responsive recommendation system (Ma & Hu, 2021), exemplifies how algorithmic prowess can disrupt established platform hierarchies. Moreover, the rise of generative AI introduces a new dimension to this power dynamic. It democratizes content creation, potentially leveling the playing field between high- and low-status actors on digital platforms (Brynjolfsson, Li & Raymond, 2023). This shift challenges traditional power structures as the ability to produce high-quality content becomes more widely accessible.

Future research must grapple with the tension between manipulation and resistance in this algorithmic landscape. How do intelligent systems simultaneously enhance platform owners' influence while providing tools for users to assert their agency? What are the implications of this ongoing push and pull for platform governance and user empowerment? It is also crucial to investigate potential unintended consequences, including new forms of algorithmic subjugation. As the boundaries between human and machine agency blur, how might power dynamics shift in ways that current governance models are ill-equipped to handle?

The evolution of algorithms from mere tools to active participants in digital ecosystems necessitates a deeper understanding of their role in shaping power dynamics. This relational perspective offers a rich avenue for future research, promising insights that could reshape our understanding of organizational power in the digital age. Researchers must explore how the interdependencies between humans and machines continue to evolve on digital platforms, shaping complex power relations. This includes studying how actors leverage intelligent algorithms to influence others beyond their typical status and resources, and how this reshapes existing power structures. As we navigate this new terrain, it is crucial to examine not only how algorithms enable new forms of control but also how they foster novel forms of resistance and empowerment. This dialectical approach to algorithmic power offers a richer understanding of the evolving digital landscape and its implications for organizational power structures. By adopting this perspective, future studies can provide valuable insights into the ongoing evolution of human–machine interactions and their impact on the distribution of power within digital platforms.

Proposition 4. The distribution of power on digital platforms will increasingly depend upon how well platform actors can coordinate and control digital agents.

Digital Citizenship and Alternative Approaches to Platform Governance

Yet another fertile line of inquiry involves the growing complexity of power dynamics on digital

platforms and the limits of platform owners to use contractual mechanisms through terms and conditions to govern user behavior on digital platforms, highlighting the need for alternative approaches to platform governance beyond those grounded in TCT (Chen, Tong, et al., 2022). As discussed above, the dynamic transformation of power relations, balancing operations, and governance structures suggests that future research would be well-served by exploring new models that incorporate the fluctuating power relations that characterize digital platforms (Siltaloppi & Vargo, 2017). In particular, research in political sociology and political theory offers alternative ways to approach questions of platform governance that extend beyond traditional TCT models (Chen et al., 2021; Gawer, 2022; Gorwa, 2019b).

One of the key premises of these approaches contends that "semi-decentralization is more likely to be associated with superior platform performance"—further noting that "a semi-decentralized governance structure is characterized by giving community members freedom and rights to participate in platform governance while having some key organizations or individuals sponsor and shape platform governance" (Chen et al., 2021). This notion of elevating the "freedom and rights" of platform participants over terms and conditions illustrates the broader utility of exploring various democratic governance models for digital platforms in future research. The approach recognizes both the power and influence of various meta-actors, including the platform itself, but also recognizes the importance of the community of users and platform participants to the functioning of the digital platform.

Reframing terms and conditions as freedom and rights shifts the description of users and participants as contractual customers to those of "digital citizens"—an ambiguous category in the context of digital platforms that is in need of further theoretical refinement and specification in future research. In an ideal form, digital citizenship describes a set of norms, practices, and behaviors that define socially beneficial activities by individuals in digital environments (Mossberger, Tolbert & McNeal, 2008). For political sociologists, the concept of citizenship is rooted in classical perspectives on the rights and responsibilities afforded to an individual social membership in a political or organizational entity, of which democratic governance remains one of several dominant types of political governance (Roche, 1987). In the context of digital platforms, digital citizenry reflects the freedoms, rights, and responsibilities afforded to different actors by virtue of their "membership" on the platform.

While democratic governance systems likely solve several key governance problems on digital platforms by allowing for the active participation of "members" in the decision-making processes of the platform (Komljenovic, 2021), other problems have surfaced regarding how membership is defined and controlled (Jacobides et al., 2018; Kretschmer et al., 2022; Martin, Upham & Klapper, 2017; Sadowski, 2020). Furthermore, digital citizens living in different political systems are likely to conceive of their freedoms, rights, and responsibilities in very different ways from other members. Reframing customers as members also surfaces questions about the resolution of competing freedoms, rights, and responsibilities of members versus other stakeholder groups, such as shareholders (Frenken & Fuenfschilling, 2021; Törnberg & Uitermark, 2020).

At the same time, the positive view of "digital citizenry" is offset by the reality of "digital deviance" on these platforms. As we discussed above, the rise of generative AI and other related technologies provide unprecedented opportunities for malicious actors to promulgate their content at a speed and scale unimaginable to "citizens" of another era, especially those due to the active manipulation of public discourse and social exchange. Moreover, these digital citizens sometimes engage in a variety of deviant behaviors, ranging from the sale of illegal substances like drugs (Liu & Bharadwaj, 2020; Mackey, Kalyanam, Katsuki & Lanckriet, 2017) to engaging in racist behavior (Agarwal & Sen, 2022). Organizational scholars can play a key role by investigating the extent to which these platform governance challenges generate implications that infiltrate the basic building blocks of human interaction, asking: Are we witnessing the end of authenticity? What constitutes exemplary "digital citizenship?" Can good citizenship be incentivized? Can it be enforced? If so, how—and with what consequences? Over the long term, how does digital citizenry favorably and unfavorably impact our non-digital interactions?

Proposition 5. The allocation and assumption of rights and responsibilities on digital platforms will increasingly determine the effectiveness of platform governance strategies and structures in enhancing the collective benefits attained through digital platforms.

Reconceptualizing Complex Power Dynamics on Digital Platforms

As each of these future research opportunities suggest, the evolving landscape of digital platforms

demands a paradigm shift in how we conceptualize and study the emerging sources and substance of the power dynamics that will shape our lives for decades to come (Earl, Maher & Pan, 2022; Hurni et al., 2022). Existing research has focused primarily on distinctions between top-down and bottom-up transaction-centric control mechanisms exerted by platform stakeholders (Cameron & Rahman, 2022; Cennamo, 2021), but this approach fails to capture the intricate web of influences shaping today's digital ecosystems (Nambisan & Baron, 2021). We propose a new research agenda that examines power as a fluid, multidirectional force distributed across diverse actors within these spaces. This direction encourages scholars to explore the emergence of informal leadership roles and influence networks among platform users, independent of official hierarchies. It calls for investigation into the collective governance mechanisms employed by user communities to self-regulate and shape platform policies. Researchers should also consider how control over data flows creates new power dynamics among users, third-party developers, and platform owners, consistent with a multisided perspective (e.g., Rahman et al., 2024).

The delicate interplay of power structures across interconnected digital spaces offers a rich area for study, as influences from one platform may ripple through to others in unexpected ways. By embracing this holistic perspective, researchers can uncover novel insights into the nature of authority, influence, and resistance within digital realms. This approach not only challenges our existing notions of organizational power but also holds potential for developing more effective and equitable governance models for the digital age. This research direction builds upon theories of distributed power, such as Foucault's (1983) concept of "power as a strategic game," while adapting them to the unique characteristics of digital ecosystems. It aims to provide a foundation for addressing pressing issues in platform governance, from content moderation to data privacy, by recognizing the complex interplay of forces shaping these environments. Through this lens, we can better understand and navigate the various problems associated with multifaceted power dynamics that increasingly define our digital world.

Building on this approach raises numerous questions for future research concerning the complex resource and power dependencies shaping the governance decisions on digital platforms, particularly the role and use of relational power and relational governance mechanisms on these platforms. In this vein, future research should ask: How do various actors leverage "balancing operations" (Emerson, 1962) to address power asymmetries? How can alternative approaches to theorizing power more fully grapple with the array of problems facing digital platforms? In what ways does the very structure and design of platforms undermine the use of either hierarchical or relational power (Kretschmer et al., 2022)? Is there justification for skepticism as to whether digital platforms—particularly those that are designed for anonymous exchanges by physically disconnected actors—can be governed at all without external regulation (Andreoni & Roberts, 2022; Cioffi, Kenney & Zysman, 2022; Cusumano, 2020; Kjaer & Vetterlein, 2018)? On this point, Foucault's (1983: 92) insights into the nature of power are particularly useful since he presents a more dynamic and fluid approach to theorizing power, which he describes, in part, as a "multiplicity of force relations." In this sense, state regulatory power represents one type of "force relations," but each of the actors upon which we focus offers alternative ways to explore the enactment and use of power on digital platforms. The ability of actors to work in concert with other actors both within and across platforms alters the political arena in which power is contested on digital platforms. In this sense, power is not a structural "artifact" that can be wielded solely through the ownership and control of a single platform. Ultimately, as actors learn to cooperate and coordinate action within or even across digital platforms, they will generate a potent "multiplicity of force relations" that will fundamentally shape and transform digital platforms.

Proposition 6. The evolution and effectiveness of a multiplicity of force relations on digital platforms will increasingly be determined by the emergence of coalitions and collective action both within and across digital platforms.

CONCLUSION

From the outset, we have asserted that in several critical respects, platform governance and power dynamics remain an enigmatic puzzle for organizational scholars. Given the dizzying rate of technological change, scholars, practitioners, and policymakers can be forgiven if they fail to ever fully "solve" the platform governance puzzle. However, it is imperative that digital platforms are, at the very least, understood; and, based on our comprehensive review of the digital platform governance literatures, we submit

that a critical missing link to gaining that understanding is directly related to the power dynamics that lie within and emanate from the manner in which platforms are both free spaces and battlegrounds. This requires developing a deeper knowledge of the multiplicity of force relations as they manifest in the digital age. As Gaventa (2003: 3) wrote, "Foucault is one of the few writers on power who recognizes that power is not just a negative, coercive or repressive force that compels us to do things against our wishes, but can also be a necessary, productive and positive force in society." The future study and practice of platform governance will likely hinge upon how effectively platform stakeholders—and society more broadly—navigate the labyrinth of free spaces and battlegrounds across a multiplicity of digital platforms upon which we live our daily lives. In this respect, management and organizational scholars have an opportunity to provide critical insights.

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